

Introduction to Social Networks



What are Social Networks?

A **social network** is a digital space where people, groups, or organizations connect with each other. Think of it like a big online community where you can share ideas, photos, news, and chat with friends or even people from other countries.

Social networks are the heart of the internet today. They help us stay in touch, learn new things, and express ourselves. Every day, millions of people use social networks to communicate, work, and have fun.

- ♦ **Key features:** profiles, news feeds, friends/followers, messages, and reactions (likes, comments, shares).
- ♦ **Why they matter:** they build communities, spread information fast, and give everyone a voice.
- ♦ **Digital identity:** how you show yourself online — your posts, photos, and interactions.

★ Social networks are like virtual cities — each with its own culture and rules.



Types of Social Media

There are many kinds of social media, and each one serves a different purpose. Here are the **six main types** you should know:



Social Networking



Media Sharing

These are for connecting with people you know or want to know. You share updates, photos, and life events.

- **Examples:** Facebook, LinkedIn
- Perfect for keeping in touch and building professional relationships.

Focus on visual content — photos, videos, and live streams. Very popular with creative people.

- **Examples:** Instagram, YouTube, TikTok
- Great for storytelling, entertainment, and learning.

Microblogging

Short, quick posts that appear in a feed. Often used for news and public conversations.

- **Examples:** X (Twitter), Threads
- Real-time updates, trends, and opinions.

Discussion Forums

Places where people ask questions, share knowledge, and dive deep into topics.

- **Examples:** Reddit, Quora
- Ideal for learning, problem-solving, and niche communities.

Social Commerce

Platforms where you can discover products, read reviews, and buy things directly.

- **Examples:** Pinterest, Instagram Shops
- Mixes shopping with social interaction.

Virtual Worlds

Immersive 3D spaces where you create an avatar and interact with others in games or virtual environments.

- **Examples:** Roblox, Fortnite
- Fun, social, and often used for events and concerts.

 **These six types cover almost everything you see on social media today.**



Popular Social Media Platforms

A **platform** is the actual app or website where people use social media. Each platform has its own style, audience, and features. Below are the most used platforms in 2026 – with simple explanations.

Facebook

The biggest social network. You can join groups, follow pages, sell items, and plan events.

~2.9 billion monthly users

YouTube

The world's largest video platform. You can watch, like, comment, and even upload your own videos.

~2.5 billion monthly users

X (Twitter)

Microblogging for short posts (tweets). Great for breaking news, sports, and public discussion.

~550 million monthly users

LinkedIn

Professional network for jobs, career advice, and business content.

~900 million members



Instagram

Photo and video sharing with filters, Stories, and Reels. Very popular with influencers.

~2 billion monthly users



TikTok

Short, catchy videos powered by a smart algorithm. Music, dance, comedy, and trends.

~1.5 billion monthly users



Threads

Text-based app for public conversations. It's connected to Instagram and feels like Twitter.

~200 million monthly users



Discord

Community servers with voice, video, and text chat. Loved by gamers and hobbyists.

~200 million monthly users

☀️ Each platform has a unique **vibe and audience** — that's why people use different ones for different purposes.



Social Media Monitoring (Listening)

What is it? Monitoring means watching what people say about a brand, topic, or person on social media.

- ✓ **Protect reputation:** quickly find and fix negative comments or problems.
- ✓ **Know your competitors:** see what others in your field are doing.
- ✓ **Understand customers:** learn what people like, dislike, and need.
- ✓ **Measure campaigns:** check if your posts are reaching and engaging people.
- ✓ **Spot trends:** discover new hashtags, memes, or topics before they explode.



Important Metrics

- ▶ **Volume** – how many times you're mentioned
- ▶ **Sentiment** – is the tone positive, neutral, or negative?
- ▶ **Reach** – how many people saw the post
- ▶ **Engagement** – likes, shares, comments, clicks
- ▶ **Share of voice** – your brand vs. competitors
- ▶ **Influencer impact** – who is talking about you?



Tools: Brandwatch, Hootsuite, Mention, Sprout Social



Monitoring Process – 4 Easy Steps

1. **Set your goal:** What do you want to learn? (e.g., brand health, campaign performance)

2. **Pick keywords and sources:** your brand name, hashtags, competitors, and industry words.
3. **Collect and analyze data:** use tools or manual checks — look for patterns and feelings.
4. **Take action:** reply to customers, improve your strategy, and share what you learned.



Remember: Always respect privacy and follow the rules (like GDPR).

Why is Social Media Monitoring So Important?

Imagine you have a shop, and people are talking about it outside — but you can't hear them. Monitoring is like putting a microphone outside your shop. You hear what people really think. That helps you make better products, answer questions faster, and build trust. It also helps you catch problems early before they become big. For students, learning monitoring is like learning to read the room — it's a super useful skill for any career.

- ◆ Companies use monitoring to improve customer service.
- ◆ Politicians use it to understand public opinion.
- ◆ Artists use it to see how fans react to new music.
- ◆ And you can use it to see what people think about your favorite topics!